

INTERNAL DEVELOPMENTS IN ETHIOPIA UNDER MENILEK II AND LIJ IYYASU: TERRITORIAL EXPANSION, MODERNIZATION, AND SOCIO- ECONOMIC TRANSFORMATION

Introduction

The late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries were crucial in shaping the Ethiopian state into a centralized and unified political entity. During this period, Ethiopian rulers pursued territorial expansion, socio-economic development, modernization of administration, and military reform, often encountering significant resistance from local communities, rival lords, and foreign powers. Among these rulers, Menilek II of Shewa was particularly successful in achieving large-scale territorial expansion and laying the foundations for modern state institutions.

The internal developments during Menilek II's reign and the short tenure of Lij Iyasu can be examined through three major lenses: territorial expansion, modernization efforts, and socio-economic transformation. These developments were not only military or administrative in nature but also profoundly affected the social, economic, and cultural fabric of Ethiopia.

I. Territorial Expansion

Territorial expansion was the most visible aspect of Menilek II's internal policy. Successive Ethiopian rulers had pursued conquest, but Menilek's campaigns stood out due to access to modern firearms, control over resource-rich areas, and the dedication of his generals. His expansion can be categorized into three phases:

- As King of Shewa (1865–1889)
- From coronation to the Battle of Adwa (1889–1896)
- Post-Adwa consolidation (1896–1900)

1. Early Expansion: King of Shewa

Before his coronation, Menilek had successfully incorporated the Tulama and Eastern Mecha Oromo territories. He gained control over local leaders, including Ashe Rufo of Salale, Dula Ara'e of Gullale, Tufa Muna of Gimbichu, and Ture Galate of Soddo, either through alliances or military campaigns. Menilek also benefited from the support of key military leaders such as Ras Gobana Dache, Fitawrari Habte-Giorgis

Dinagde, and Dejjach Balcha Safo (Abba Nefso), who provided the strategic guidance needed for the expansion.

In the northern Gurage, also known as the Kistane, local communities submitted peacefully between 1875 and 1876 due to shared religious beliefs and geographic proximity to Shewa, combined with fear of surrounding Oromo groups. Conversely, the western Gurage, under the leadership of Hasan Enjamo Qabena, resisted Menilek's forces, necessitating military intervention by Ras Gobana, who subdued them in 1888.

2. Southern and Western Expansion

The area south of the Abay River, particularly Horro Guduru, had been under the control of Ras Adal Tesema of Gojjam since the mid-1870s. Menilek's forces clashed repeatedly with the Gojjam army, including confrontations at Chomman and Kokor, before decisively defeating them at the Battle of Embabo (6 June 1882). Subsequently, regions such as Leqa-Naqamte, Leqa-Qellem, and Jimma Abba Jifar peacefully submitted under promises of local autonomy, illustrating Menilek's ability to combine military action with political negotiation.

Resistance persisted in other areas. A coalition of local leaders including Garbi Jilo (Leqa-Billo), Tucho Dano (Leqa-Horda), Ligdi Bakare (Leqa-Naqamte), Genda Busan (Sibu-Sire), Mardasa Konche (Nonno Migira), and Turi Jagan (Nonno Rogge) successfully defeated Shewan forces led by the Nadew brothers (Dasta, Dilinesaw, and Tesemma) at the Battle of Gara Dobbi. Similarly, along the western Didessa River, an alliance of Wachu Dabalo (Sibu), Jorgo Dagago (Noole Kabba) and others resisted Menilek's local allies like Moroda and Amante Bakare at Sambo Darro, indicating that territorial expansion involved prolonged, region-specific conflicts.

In the Gibe region, resistance persisted between 1889 and 1901, with leaders such as Firissa of Guma and Abba Bosso of Gomma opposing Menilek's armies. These areas were eventually integrated into the empire by commanders like Ras Demisew Nesibu and Ras Tesemma Nadew, who incorporated Ilu Abba Bor after a series of battles with local leaders like Fatansa at Qersa Gogila.

3. Campaigns Against the Arsi Oromo (1882–1886)

Among Menilek's pre-coronation campaigns, the six campaigns against the Arsi Oromo were the most prolonged and bloody. Local leaders such as Sufa Kuso, Damu Usu, Lenjiso Diga, Gosa Dilamo, and Roba Butta initially defeated Menilek's army at Dodota and Qal'ata. However, with intelligence from local supporters, Ras Darge

Sahile-Selassie led forces that defeated the Arsi at Azule (6 September 1886). This was followed by the Anole incident (1887), which inflicted severe retribution on the Arsi, though historians debate its scale. These campaigns demonstrate both Menilek's military persistence and the significant human cost of expansion.

4. Eastern Expansion: Chercher and Harar

Menilek's eastern campaigns were led by commanders Dejjach Wolde-Gabr'el and Dejjach Mekonnen. In 1886, Wolde-Gabr'el incorporated Chercher, and a year later, Mekonnen's army marched into Harar, defeating Emir Abdullahi (r. 1885–1887) and the Bakar Ware of Eastern Oromo at the Battle of Chalanqo (6 January 1887). This campaign established Ras Makonnen as the provincial governor and extended imperial control into a culturally distinct and strategically important region.

5. Southern Expansion During the Great Famine (1888–1892)

The Great Famine (Kifu Qen, 1888–1892) weakened southern states, allowing Menilek's forces to expand into Dawuro-Konta, Kambata, Bale, Sidama, Gamo Gofa, Wolayta, Gedeo, Borana, and Konso. In Wolayta, the local king, Kawo Tona, resisted fiercely. Menilek, accompanied by high-ranking figures such as Ras Mikael, Fitawrari Gebeyehu Gurmu, Liqe Mekwas Abate Buayalew, Dejjach Balcha Safo, Ras Wolde-Giorgis Abboye, and Abba Jifar II, eventually defeated Wolayta's forces in 1894, resulting in heavy casualties. Similarly, Kafa resisted under King Tato Gaki Sherocho before succumbing to Menilek's army in 1897, illustrating the high human cost of expansion. The incorporation of Beni Shangul-Gumuz, following the Battle of Fadogno (1897–1898), and the control of Maji, Baro (Sobat), and Nasir in Gambella, further extended the empire's reach to western frontiers.

6. The Battle of Adwa and Consolidation (1896–1900)

Tensions with Italy, arising from differing interpretations of the Treaty of Wuchale (1889), culminated in the historic Battle of Adwa on 1 March 1896. Italy attempted to impose colonial control over Ethiopia, but Menilek responded by mobilizing an estimated 100,000 troops drawn from diverse regions including Shewa, Gojjam, Wollo, Tigray, and the recently incorporated southern territories. This large-scale national mobilization reflected the degree of unity achieved through Menilek's earlier territorial expansions.

The leadership structure during Adwa demonstrated the effectiveness of Menilek's centralized military system. He coordinated with key figures such as Empress Taytu, Ras Mekonnen, Ras Mikael, Ras Alula, Ras Gobena, and Fitawrari Gebeyehu. Their

combined strategic planning, use of local geography, and disciplined coordination allowed Ethiopia to confront and overpower the Italian forces. The battle ended in a decisive Ethiopian victory approximately 8,000 Italian troops were killed, many captured, and the invading army was forced into retreat. Ethiopian losses were estimated between 4,000–6,000.

This outcome led to the Treaty of Addis Ababa (26 October 1896), which secured Ethiopia's independence and ensured Italy recognized the country as a sovereign state. Beyond its diplomatic significance, the victory elevated Menilek's legitimacy, strengthened internal cohesion, and positioned Ethiopia as the only African nation to successfully repel European colonial aggression during the Scramble for Africa. The symbolic power of Adwa also resonated globally, inspiring anti-colonial movements and later Pan-Africanist leaders, including figures such as Marcus Garvey.

In the aftermath of Adwa, Menilek continued consolidating Ethiopia's territorial sovereignty by negotiating boundaries with neighboring colonial powers, including French Somaliland (Djibouti), British Somaliland, Italian Eritrea, Anglo-Egyptian Sudan, and British East Africa (Kenya). These diplomatic agreements helped stabilize Ethiopia's borders and further reinforced the central authority that Menilek had built before and after the victory at Adwa.

7. Post-Adwa Consolidation

After the Battle of Adwa (1 March 1896), Menilek focused on consolidating the empire and reducing regional autonomies. Provinces like Wollo, Begemidir, Gojjam, and Jimma were eventually reduced to administrative units under Teferi-Mekonnen (later Haile Selassie I) in the early twentieth century, demonstrating the long-term impact of Menilek's centralization policies.

II. Modernization Efforts and Internal Developments

Menilek II's reign was characterized by extensive modernization efforts that built upon earlier initiatives of Tewodros II and Yohannes IV, but were adapted to Ethiopia's diverse social, political, and geographical realities. His reforms spanned military, administrative, infrastructural, educational, and socio-economic spheres, accompanied by the incorporation of newly conquered territories.

1. Military and Administrative Reforms

Menilek II continued and expanded the military reforms introduced by Tewodros II. He introduced modern military ranks, including Yasr Alaqa (corporal), Yamsa Alaqa (sergeant), and Yashi Alaqa (major), which standardized the command structure of his

forces. To consolidate imperial authority, he replaced fragmented regional militias with a salaried national army, incorporating firearms and artillery acquired through European contacts, significantly improving the military capabilities of the empire.

In 1907, Menilek established a European-style ministerial system, professionalizing governance and reducing reliance on ad hoc local administration. The new ministerial posts included:

- Minister of Justice (Afe-Nigus Nesibu Meskelo)
- Minister of the Imperial Court (Azazh Metaferia Melke-Tsadiq)
- Minister of Finance (Bejirond Mulugeta Yigezu)
- Minister of War (Fitawrari Habte-Giorgis Dinagde)
- Minister of Commerce and Foreign Relations (Negadras Hailegiorgis Weldemikael)
- Minister of Pen (Tsehafe-Tizaz Gebre-Selase Welde Aregay)

These reforms allowed for more centralized decision-making and a structured bureaucracy, while also providing mechanisms for more effective control over the expanded territories.

2. Infrastructure and Communication

Menilek II prioritized the development of infrastructure and communication networks to integrate the empire and facilitate trade, administration, and military control.

- Postal services and telegraph/telephone systems connected provincial administrations with the central government, enhancing governance efficiency.
- The Djibouti–Addis Ababa railway, completed in 1917, was instrumental in promoting trade, stimulating urban growth, and integrating the newly incorporated southern and eastern provinces into the imperial economy.
- Garrison towns (katamas), including Gobba, Ticho, Gore, and Arjo, were strategically established to maintain military presence and enforce imperial authority in conquered territories.
- Urban development was further supported through the construction of key buildings, such as Taytu Hotel (Itege Hotel), which provided infrastructure for administration, accommodation, and urban settlement.

3. Education, Health, and Social Reform

Education and healthcare reforms under Menilek II reflected a commitment to modernization and societal development:

- Menilek II School (1908) promoted literacy and modern education, often employing foreign teachers to introduce new methods and curricula.
- Hospitals, such as the Russian Red Cross Hospital (1906) and Menilek II Hospital (1910), improved public health and introduced more systematic medical care.
- Empress Taytu played a key role in urban planning, selecting Addis Ababa for its hot springs (Hora Finfinne) in 1886, which led to its proclamation as the imperial capital and accelerated administrative organization.

4. Banking and Currency Reforms

Menilek II introduced modern financial institutions and currency reforms to support trade, administration, and economic stability:

- **Silver Coins:** To standardize trade and taxation, Menilek II introduced locally minted silver coins, modeled on the widely used Maria Theresa thalers. These coins facilitated commerce across newly incorporated regions and strengthened the central government's economic control.
- **Bank of Abyssinia (1905):** Menilek II established the first modern bank in Ethiopia, the Bank of Abyssinia, in collaboration with a British banking company. The bank issued banknotes, provided loans, and managed government revenue, marking a significant step in modernizing the country's financial system.

These reforms encouraged commercial activity, supported urban growth, and helped integrate the southern and eastern provinces into the imperial economy. They also reflected Menilek's broader goal of aligning Ethiopia's economy with international standards while maintaining sovereignty.

III. Socio-Economic Developments

1. Agriculture and Land Tenure

The incorporation of southern territories during Menilek II's expansion fundamentally altered land use and social hierarchies:

- The *naftegna-gabbar* system placed local populations under tribute obligations to northern soldiers (*naftegna*), creating new social structures with *ballabat* (landlords), *gabbar*, and tenants.
- The *qalad* system (land measurement), introduced in the 1890s, formalized land ownership, often dispossessing local peasants while rewarding loyal

officials, thereby consolidating imperial control and shaping agricultural practices.

2. Manufacturing and Urbanization

Expatriates introduced industrial activities that transformed Ethiopia's economy:

- Factories and industrial facilities included Holeta Grain Mill (1896), Massawa Salt Processing (1904), cement factories, tanneries, soap and oil production, ammunition factories, Artistic Printing Press, and Ambo Mineral Water Plant.
- Urban centers such as Addis Ababa, Dire Dawa, Adama, Mojo, and Bishoftu expanded rapidly due to railway construction, administrative consolidation, and the strategic placement of garrison towns.

IV. Foreign Relations

1. Treaties and Agreements

Menilek engaged extensively with foreign powers to secure arms, trade, and recognition. Early agreements included commercial relations with Italy and treaties with Britain, France, and Egypt. The Treaty of Wuchale (1889) became controversial due to differing Amharic and Italian texts regarding foreign diplomacy. Menilek abrogated the treaty in 1893, asserting Ethiopian sovereignty. Subsequent boundary agreements established borders with French Somaliland (1897), British Somaliland (1897), Italian Eritrea (1900), Anglo-Egyptian Sudan (1902), British East Africa (1907), and Italian Somaliland (1908).

Internal Developments under Abeto/Lij Iyasu (1913–1916)

The short reign of Lij Iyasu, who ruled from 1913 to 1916, represented a transitional phase in Ethiopia's history. He inherited an empire that had been largely unified and centralized under Menilek II, but his rule was marked by attempts to modernize administration, introduce social reforms, and consolidate imperial authority. Despite his progressive vision, Lij Iyasu faced considerable resistance from conservative elites, regional lords, and religious authorities, which limited the full realization of his policies.

I. Territorial Administration and Consolidation

Although Lij Iyasu did not embark on major territorial expansion comparable to Menilek II, he continued to maintain control over the newly incorporated regions of southern and western Ethiopia. His approach emphasized administrative oversight and integration rather than military conquest. He relied on the structures established by

Menilek II, including regional governors and a central army, to ensure stability in provinces that had previously resisted imperial authority.

II. Modernization Efforts and Administrative Reforms

Lij Iyasu introduced several reforms aimed at modernizing governance and improving the justice system:

- **Judicial Reforms** – He abolished the quragna system, which had chained plaintiffs and defendants until disputes were settled, reflecting a move toward more humane and systematic judicial practices. The leba shay system, a traditional investigative method for detecting criminals, was also reformed to improve fairness and effectiveness.
- **Law Enforcement** – A modern municipal police force called Tirbulle was established in Addis Ababa, marking the introduction of organized policing in the capital.
- **Administrative Integration** – Lij Iyasu attempted to integrate Ethiopian Muslims into the administrative framework, signaling an effort to create a more inclusive governance structure and reduce religious and ethnic marginalization.

III. Economic and Industrial Initiatives

Lij Iyasu promoted small-scale industrialization to stimulate the domestic economy:

- Flour mills, sawmills, and tanneries were established to support local production.
- Soap factories were introduced as part of efforts to diversify manufacturing and reduce reliance on imports.

These initiatives reflected his broader vision of economic modernization, though their impact was limited by the short duration of his reign and resistance from conservative factions.

IV. Resistance and Challenges

Despite these reformist measures, Lij Iyasu faced significant opposition:

- Conservative elites and the Ethiopian Orthodox Church viewed his reforms and policies favoring Muslims as threatening traditional authority structures.
- Regional lords in some provinces resisted central control, maintaining local influence and challenging the imperial agenda.
- His perceived favoritism toward certain ethnic and religious groups contributed to political instability, culminating in his deposition in 1916.

V. Social and Political Significance

Although Lij Iyasu's reign was brief, his policies reflected an early attempt to modernize Ethiopia along more inclusive and progressive lines. His judicial reforms, law enforcement initiatives, and industrial projects were precursors to later modernization efforts under Empress Zewditu and Emperor Haile Selassie I. However, the resistance he faced highlights the challenges of balancing reform with entrenched social and political interests in early twentieth-century Ethiopia.

Conclusion

The reigns of Menilek II and Lij Iyasu were transformative for Ethiopia. Menilek's territorial expansion unified the empire, established centralized administration, and integrated diverse regions. Modernization efforts in governance, infrastructure, military, education, and healthcare laid the foundations for the Ethiopian state. Lij Iyasu attempted further reforms to modernize administration, industry, and justice systems.

These developments not only strengthened Ethiopia internally but also secured its sovereignty against colonial encroachment, culminating in the celebrated Battle of Adwa, a symbol of African resistance to European imperialism. The period thus represents a decisive chapter in the formation of modern Ethiopia, with lasting social, economic, and political consequences.